Revisionist, a supporter of settlements and “greater Israel”, but also a classical liberal, committed to the rule of law and the separation of powers. In 1979, the Supreme Court ordered him to remove the settlement of Elon Moreh, which was built (like Amona) on privately-owned Palestinian land. “Naturally we shall not make any announcements, which are completely unnecessary, saying that the Supreme Court’s decision should be respected,” he said at a cabinet meeting shortly after the verdict. “They are unnecessary, because this goes without saying.” The settlement was relocated to a nearby hilltop—again, Begin was hardly a leftist—but there was no question about the court’s authority.

The younger Begin followed in his father’s footsteps, denouncing the outpost bill as a “land grab”. After the vote, David Bitan, the coalition chairman, suspended him from his parliamentary committees for breaking coalition discipline. One of those roles, ironically, was on the constitution and law committee.

“It’s not the horses”

Thousands of homes in dozens of settlements had been “legalized”, but the forty families in Amona—the original reason for this whole sordid affair—still faced eviction in two-and-a-half weeks, with no alternative housing arranged. Naturally, they were upset. By the time I drove out there on a blustery, rainy day in mid-December, they had been joined by hundreds of supporters. Their ranks included Kahanists, “Hilltop Youth” members, and teenagers affiliated with Lehava, the far-right anti-miscegenation group. Many had already spent days camping in the freezing cold. The actual residents of Amona said privately that they planned to resist the demolition order, but peacefully: they would make the police drag them out of their homes, but they wouldn’t fight back. Their supporters were less tranquil. They had stockpiled tires, to burn as roadblocks, and also a pile of iron rods.

Amona had been evacuated once before, in 2006, and it was a violent affair. More than 200 people had been wounded, including dozens of police officers. The Likud party had used footage of the melee against Ehud Olmert in the subsequent general election, releasing a video entitled “It’s not the horses”, which featured clips of mounted cops clad in riot gear. The implication was that Olmert was to blame for the violence. Netanyahu was